

cents per share, but we would have a really hard time finding a buyer for 3,400 shares of this stock right now. It might take a week or so to sell it all off and by selling so much at once, it could really drive the price down!”

About two weeks later Aaron got a check for the total value of what was left, \$2,380. This was not enough to pay off his credit card cash advances of \$4,000 plus the added interest. Although it sounds like a nightmare, Aaron should have felt lucky he got any of his money back at all!

Being open to new opportunities is not unwise. However, the source of these new opportunities should be scrutinized thoroughly. Was the source an unknown person over the phone, a tip from a client about a start-up venture, or advice from a financial message board on the Internet? The motivation behind the referrals might be very self-serving. For example, the Internet message board might be attempting to influence a stock's price. Anonymous message posters can be placed as a way to run up a stock's price. In Aaron's case, he should have followed the golden rule: don't ever buy stock or other investments from someone you don't know and trust.

If you insist on taking a gamble, make sure you have a strong enough portfolio to allow you to take a high-risk investment every once in a while. It is never recommended to use any of your retirement money for a high-risk investment, and you should definitely limit the investment to no more than 10 percent of your discretionary funds. But don't ever borrow money on a credit card for something that seems like a get-rich-quick opportunity. The best advice for someone like Nick—if something sounds too good to be true, it probably is!

A con artist is difficult to detect by appearance or tone of voice alone. But you can often spot him or her by their words or expressions:

